

Cervus elaphus

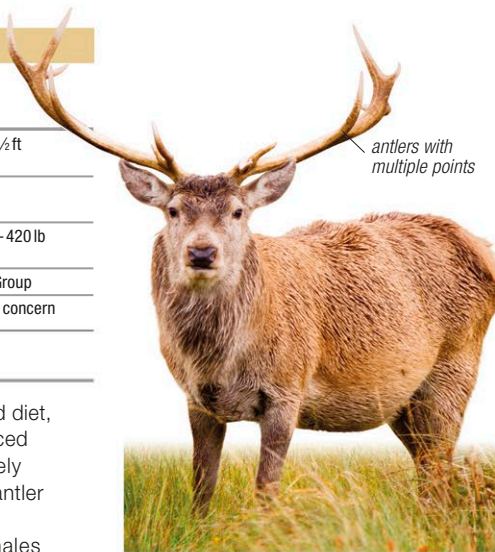
Red deer



Length 5–6½ ft (1.5–2 m)
Tail 4¾ in (12 cm)
Weight 145–420 lb (65–190 kg)
Location Europe, Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Highly adaptable in habitat and diet, the red deer has been introduced to most continents and is widely farmed for meat, hides, and antler velvet. There is great variation among the 6 subspecies. Females (hinds) form herds led by a dominant hind, with separate male bands except during the fall rut.



antlers with multiple points

MORE BROWN THAN RED
Red deer are red-brown in summer, perhaps with a dark line along the neck and back, and vague flank spots, and then turn dull brown in winter.

RUTTING

Red deer males (stags), like most other male deer, battle during the rutting season. The contest is part display and part physical tussle. Stags roar and bellow, thrash their antlers against bushes and trees, and walk parallel to each other, as they assess whether to fight. If so, they lock antlers, push, twist, and shove. The winner gains a harem.



Cervus nippon

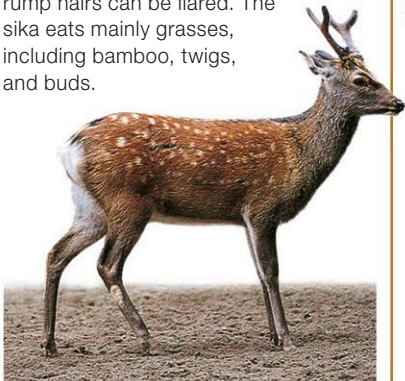
Sika



Length 3¾–6¼ ft (1.1–1.9 m)
Tail 3¾–7 in (10–18 cm)
Weight 44–308 lb (20–140 kg)
Location E. and S.E. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The sika has been kept in parks and farmed for centuries, and has been introduced into many regions. Appearance varies among the 10 subspecies, some of which are endangered, but is generally rich red-brown with white spots in summer, and almost black in winter, with perhaps vague spotting on females. The white rump hairs can be flared. The sika eats mainly grasses, including bamboo, twigs, and buds.



Elaphurus davidianus

Père David's deer



Length 6–6¾ ft (1.8–2.1 m)
Tail 14 in (35 cm)
Weight 310–485 lb (140–220 kg)
Location E. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Extinct in the wild



Distinct from other deer in its body form, this species has a long, horselike face, wide hooves, and a long tail. Also unusual are the male's (stag's) "back-to-front" antlers. The coat is dark gray-fawn in winter, bright red-brown in summer, with a dark central back stripe, and a whorled hair pattern on the rump. Extinct in the wild, the species was saved by captive breeding in England from about 1900. Since the 1980s, it has been reintroduced into the wild in China.

Odocoileus hemionus

Mule deer



Length 4¼–5¾ ft (1.3–1.8 m)
Tail 5¼–9 in (15–23 cm)
Weight 77–240 lb (35–110 kg)
Location W. North America
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The mule deer is widely distributed in many habitats, and is recorded as eating hundreds of plant species. The main color is gray-brown in winter, and rusty brown in summer. Despite its other name of black-tailed deer, the tail is black on the upper surface only; the rest is white. The face and throat also have variable white areas, with black chin and forehead bands. Rutting is in September–November; 1–2 young are usually born in June.



Odocoileus virginianus

White-tailed deer



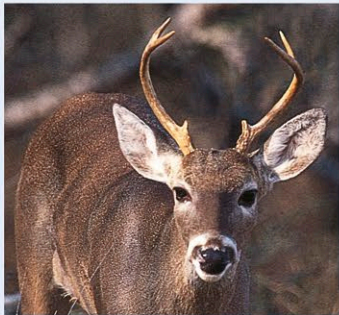
Length 3¾–6¼ ft (1.1–1.9 m)
Tail 5½–14½ in (14–37 cm)
Weight 55–285 lb (25–130 kg)
Location S. Canada to N. South America
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



This species is extremely similar in appearance and habits to the mule deer (see left), and in zoos and parks the 2 may interbreed. This rarely happens in the wild, however, even though their ranges overlap. The numerous subspecies become smaller toward the south of the range, shoulder height ranging from 3½ ft (1.1 m) in Canada to 2 ft (60 cm) in Venezuela, where it is known as the venado.



YEARLY ANTLER CYCLE



By February, the male white-tailed deer will have cast its antlers. In April–May, they start to grow again, protected by fur-covered skin (velvet), but in September all the velvet will have been rubbed off against trees, leaving the clean bone, before the rut.

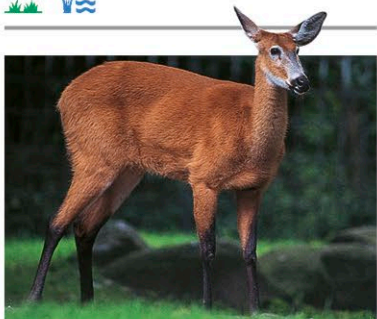
WHITE WARNING
When danger threatens, this deer raises its tail and flashes the bright white underside, as a warning to others in its herd.

Blastocerus dichotomus

Marsh deer



Length Up to 5¼–5¾ ft (1.6–1.8 m)
Tail 5–5¾ in (13–15 cm)
Weight 155–285 lb (70–130 kg)
Location C. and E. South America
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Vulnerable



Long legs and wide hooves allow the marsh deer to move easily in swamps and floodplains. The largest South American deer, it is reddish brown in summer and darker in winter, with black lower legs, a pale face, and black around the lips and nose. It eats grasses, reeds, water plants, and bushes, and lives alone or in groups of 2–3. It is threatened by habitat loss due to irrigation and conversion to pasture or crops, water pollution, and competition from livestock.